

IELTS Writing Task 1: Overview Killer Pack

Book 12 · Fix the #1 Task 1 score ceiling

Stratum IELTS · stratumielts.com

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Part of the Stratum IELTS Writing Guide Series

Who this book is for

Your Task 1 grammar is okay, but scores stay around **5.5–6.0**.

Very often the missing piece is a clear **overview**.

YouTube teachers repeat this because it is true: no overview = hard ceiling.

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1. What an overview must do

An overview is 1–2 sentences that answer:

- What is the **big picture**?
- What are the **2–3 standout features**?

It is **not**:

- a list of every number
- an introduction paraphrase
- an opinion (*this is because people like...*)

Place it after the introduction (most common) or clearly signal it with *Overall...*

2. Overview formulas

Line graph

Overall, X rose over the period despite a dip in..., while Y remained relatively stable.

Bar chart

Overall, A was the highest category in both years, whereas B remained the lowest.

Pie chart

Overall, the largest share belonged to X, while Y accounted for the smallest proportion.

Table

Overall, figures were highest in... and lowest in..., with the clearest growth in...

Process

Overall, the process consists of N stages, beginning with... and ending with...

Map

Overall, the area became more residential/commercial, with the most noticeable change in...

3. Bad vs good

Bad

The chart shows many numbers about visitors from 2010 to 2020 and there are increases and decreases.

Good

Overall, library visits increased substantially over the decade, peaking in 2018 before a slight fall in 2020.

Bad (process)

There are several steps and machines in the diagram.

Good

Overall, recycled paper is produced in seven stages, starting with collection and finishing with dried cut sheets.

4. 10-minute drill system

Do this daily for one week:

1. Open any chart/map/process (or sketch one).

2. Write **only** intro + overview (ignore details).
3. Check: can a reader see the main story without numbers overload?
4. Then optionally write details.

Rule: if overview is weak, do not continue to detail paragraphs yet.

5. Practice prompts (overview only)

Write 2-sentence overviews:

1. Line: city bike trips 2015–2025 (strong rise, small COVID dip)
2. Bars: energy use by 5 appliances in 2 years
3. Pies: transport share 2010 vs 2020
4. Process: bottled water production, 6 stages
5. Map: airport area 1995 vs 2015 (new terminal + parking)

Then expand one into a full 150-word report and check at <https://stratumielts.com>.

6. Next step

- Charts language → **Book 2**
- Maps/process detail → **Book 9**
- Common Task 1 mistakes → **Book 4**

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End of Book 12 — Overview Killer Pack